

INTRODUCTION TO NOVEL WRITING



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Introduction to Novel Writing

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About the Author

Introduction to Novel Writing

by Tamara Girardi, PhD

About the Author

Dr. Tamara Girardi is an Associate Professor of English at HACC, Central Pennsylvania's Community College, where she teaches several writing classes including Introduction to Novel Writing, the course for which this book was developed. An author of books for children and teens, Dr. Girardi's award-winning debut young adult novel, *Gridiron Girl*, tells the story of Julia Medina who quits her high school volleyball team to compete against her boyfriend for the starting quarterback position on the football team. Three additional sports novels in the Iron Valley Vikings series followed in 2022. *Above the Fold* is the first book in Tamara's second series, all about teens exploring their dreams and their true selves through exhibits at a popular, mardi-gras-esque hotspot called Carnivalesque. *Above the Fold* released in January of 2023, and its sequel, *Behind the Mask* followed in February, both from Wise Wolf Books. Tamara's debut board book, *Why, Daddy? Why?* was named a 2022 Editor's Pick by Amazon and is being followed by *Why, Mommy? Why?*, which will be released in spring of 2025. Dr. Girardi is an editor for the Digital and Multimedia/Multimodal section of the *Journal of Creative Writing Studies* and co-edited the essay collection, *Theories and Strategies for Teaching Creative Writing Online*. She is presently working on several writing projects and is eager to see them out in the world. Since HACC is an open enrollment institution, guest students can enroll in her Introduction to Novel Writing or other creative writing courses by visiting the college's website. She can be reached through her website, www.tamaragirardi.com.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Chapters

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1: What is a novel?

What is a novel? This is such a good question, and it's important for you to learn now that not everyone agrees on the answer. As is the case in any field, there is debate. Some writers believe that writing should be heavily literary to be a true novel. Others place more commercial works like romance, science fiction, or fantasy stories within the category of novel.

✓ The terms "literary fiction" and "commercial fiction"

The terms "literary fiction" and "commercial fiction" reference the style and content of a novel-length work. Literary fiction tends to be more artistic in style, and focuses on a character's internal motivations and experiences. On the contrary, commercial fiction is not read for its art but more for the entertainment value of its fast-paced plot. This is not to say that literary novels are not plotted or that commercial novels do not demonstrate character development. In fact, the best novels often implement all of these critical elements: character, plot, internal motivations, and style. Nevertheless, there is value in understanding the potential differences between these two "types" of novels.

Britannica offers this detailed definition of a novel: "an invented prose narrative of considerable length and a certain complexity that deals imaginatively with human experience, usually through a connected sequence of events involving a group of persons in a specific setting" (Novel).

When discussing the concept of a novel, writers usually mention character, setting, and plot (a connected sequence of events), but the unique aspect of Britannica's definition is "human experience." The novel, by intention and definition, explores human experience in a way that is meaningful to readers.

Adding to Britannica's definition, the novel is a longer work of fiction that relies on prose style.

Let's break down that definition a bit. First, we have "a longer work of fiction." I'll take for granted that you know fiction means a story that is not entirely true, although it can be and often is based in reality.

What does "longer work" mean? In ["Word Count for Novels and Children's Books: The Definitive Post,"](#) works of fiction are defined in terms of word count. To familiarize yourself with these conventions, read this article now, but also read it a few more times as you develop your own novels.

As you review these guidelines, keep in mind the difference between the terms "age category" and "genre." Some people will refer to young adult, or YA, as a genre, for instance. Actually, YA is an age category with many genres within it including fantasy, science fiction, romance, mystery, thriller and so on.

Age categories for novels are primarily: children's, middle grade, young adult, new adult, and adult, although there has long been debate regarding the success and therefore validity of new adult as a category.

Genres for novels are diverse including fantasy, romance, science fiction, dystopian, western, contemporary, and so many more. Within the genres, there are also sub-genres. For instance within the fantasy genre, there are sub-genres such as high fantasy, urban fantasy, sword and sorcery, historical fantasy, magical realism, etc.

Getting back to the Writer's Digest article, the word count guidelines represent the conventions for the contemporary novel. That means, writers today generally follow these word counts when they write fiction. There will always be dissenting opinions. There will always be outliers. However, for a debut author, it's best to stick to word count conventions to avoid being immediately rejected by agents and editors based on a number alone.

Is that fair? Perhaps not, but there is some logic to the approach. In an essay writing class, your professor may say they'd like to see a three-to-five-page essay or perhaps eight to ten pages. They make that recommendation based on the complexity of the topic and the expectation for depth in the writing. In other words, an essay submission that is a few pages too short likely doesn't discuss the topic to the appropriate complexity and depth. An essay that is pages beyond the target range may not be well-edited and as focused as it should be.

Similarly, novel length conventions are as they are because writers are expected to hit the marks of plot structure, character development, and world building within those word lengths. If the word count is significantly less than the target for that particular genre and age category, then perhaps the character development or world building require enrichment to truly impact readers. If the word count is too long, perhaps the author is not staying on focus with the plot structure or slowing down the pace with too much description, backstory, or setting.

The target is the target for very good reason. There will always be outliers, but you want to strive to follow conventions as much as possible.

With that caution in place, let's get back to our definition. A novel is a work of prose. What does that mean? Prose basically means writing that naturally flows like speech might, which is interesting because prose is truly determined by the narrator's voice. We will discuss narrative voice in more detail later in the text.

Furthermore, prose should generally follow the grammatical structure of spoken language. While sentence fragments are frowned upon in academic writing, they are allowed in creative writing because people naturally speak in sentence fragments. Prose, then, is closely connected to voice, as mentioned above.

As an overview, though, prose style varies based on the character's voice. For instance, imagine in your head the voice of your parent. Now imagine the voice of a young child. Those voices differ, right? Okay, what about the voice of a well-educated, rhetorically polished politician sharing their view of community needs with voters? How does that voice differ from the voice of a local mechanic talking with his co-workers? In prose, your writing should reflect these differences in character. The dialogue and narrative voice should honor the respective identities of your characters.

Prose may incorporate, and should incorporate, literary devices such as symbolism, metaphor, alliteration, and so on. However, prose is not entirely poetic. There are many writing styles. For instance, expository writing explains. Argumentative writing persuades. Prose writing, however, should show - again with the voice of the narrator in mind.

Let's look at an example:

"The engine whined against my attempt to go faster. The yellow lines of the road went by on my left in a blur. The ocean on my right didn't seem affected at all. It created the illusion that I wasn't going fast enough. The gentle curves on this road begged to be taken at high speeds. I pushed down another inch on the gas pedal and the car lurched forward. My heart picked up speed and I couldn't keep the smile from my face. Wind whipped through the cabin, sending my hair flying and drying the sweat on my forehead from my last practice of the school year. Red and blue lights flashed in my rearview mirror. I pointlessly lifted my foot off the gas pedal as if that would help." - On the Fence, by Kasie West

The voice in this YA novel is strong. The main character narrating the story shows us she loves driving fast. She describes the rush of the experience in a way that tells us she's probably done it before, and she doesn't seem surprised when a police officer catches her.

So think about this moment, this scenario, because your novel should be built on moments that show what you want the reader to see. In this action, a person is speeding. That's the simplified explanation of it. But she is somewhat unconcerned about her speeding. What does that say about her as a character?

✓ Novel Conventions

Novels have other conventions to keep in mind. Here are a few for you to consider:

- Novels tell stories. The element of story is critical to a novel.
- Some novels have multiple main characters or an ensemble of narrative voices. Others rely on one narrative voice.
- Novels include a specific structure of rising action. That structure has been defined in some cases as the hero's journey or in specific beats.
- Novels include scenes with specific goals and dialogue that follows conventions, so readers understand who is speaking.
- Novels include conflict - usually about a character who wants something desperately but cannot have it for many reasons.
- Novels include tension that keeps readers turning the pages.
- Novels are not written in one sitting. They are envisioned, rehearsed, planned, written, rewritten, re-envisioned, re-rehearsed, replanned, and rewritten yet again.
- Novels can be self-published, published by small presses, or published by large publishers with the assistance of a literary agent.
- Novels can be stand alone works, or they can be part of a larger series.
- Novels come in many forms: epistolary, romantic, historical, pastoral, detective, mystery, thriller, western, fantasy, psychological, and more.

Novels are many things. In this text, we will discuss so many of these points, but we won't cover everything. That's not possible. Many writers work on their craft and understanding of building novels for years, if not decades, before they publish. Others write a novel in a year and get published immediately. If you ask me, a lot of that depends on the amount of reading and/or planning a person has done coupled with the market—if the new writer happens to be writing on trend, publication could happen much more quickly.

Publication is not often something a writer can control though—unless the writer is self-publishing, so it's probably best not to think about that too much in this class. Or at least not until the end of the class.

First we need to learn how to write a novel. Then we have to write one.

Two very large tasks. Let's get started.

✓ Exercises

1. Visit your personal bookshelf or a public library or bookstore. Select five novels from different genres or age categories. Stack the books. What do you observe about the thickness of each spine? Place the books side by side. What do you observe about their covers? Flip the books over, and read the back cover copy. What do you observe about the marketing approach for each novel concept? What does this observation tell you about the diversity and/or conventions of novels?
2. Think about the novels you prefer to read. Do you also plan to write in that genre or age category? Or do you prefer to read in a different genre than the one you'd like to write? What can you consider about your personal preferences that helps you better plan for your experience writing a novel?
3. Let's play the imagination game again because that's why we're here. Grab a piece of paper or open a Word document on your computer. Now, I'd like you to write a brief scene in which a character is speeding, but the character should have a significantly different voice than the one in West's book above. Here are your options:
 - An elderly nun with a carful of other nuns.
 - A stressed mother of four with her children in the car.
 - An off duty police officer.

What does the character's voice, life experience, and view of the world show in the words you wrote?

✓ Additional Resources

[Novel, Britannica](#)

[The Rise of the Novel](#)

[The Rise of the Novel in the Eighteenth Century](#)

A note about the resources in this book: You will notice that many of the resources I suggest are from online websites and blogs. There are great vlogs that I have not included as well, so seek those out on Youtube. While scholarly sources are best for academic writing, I find it is often incredibly valuable to learn about the craft of writing from other writers. Don't be afraid to read a blog by an author you don't know well and consider that a valuable resource to learn about creative writing. Also, read widely! There are so many perspectives on all of these points. Don't take one perspective as fact. Explore various points of view, and decide what works best for you and your writerly journey!

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2: Pantser, Plotter, Planter - What is your writing style?

Professional writers are often asked about two things: their ideas and their process. Stephen King jokes that his ideas come from an idea factory in Ohio. In reality, writers often have an influx of ideas. They soon learn not all ideas are strong enough to develop into a novel and although the idea might seem shiny at first, you have to put it through the fire to see what it's really made of.

That brings us to the second commonly-asked question - about a writer's process. The writing process is often an elusive and complex concept for creative writers. In the fields of writing studies, there is a minimized, simple explanation of process as:

Prewriting - Drafting - Revising - Editing

Prewriting encompasses those tasks writers complete before actually drafting the scenes of their stories; it could include outlining, plotting, character development worksheets, rehearsing scenes or concepts through mental staging, and more. Drafting is as it sounds - actually "writing" the scenes whether that be with pen and paper, computer, or even oral dictation. Revising occurs when a writer rewrites previously written parts of the novel. Finally, editing is the polishing of style and correctness.

However, we know these four tasks - prewriting, drafting, revising, and editing - are recursive, so they aren't always linear. For instance, a writer might develop a project by:

Drafting a scene that came to mind - Prewriting ideas to make that scene fit into a larger whole - Drafting more scenes - Revising the original scene to fit into the new vision - Drafting more scenes - Prewriting to sort through some of the themes and concepts - etc.

As you can see, the process for the writer in this hypothetical example was not a linear: prewriting, drafting, revising, and editing. It was more: drafting, prewriting, drafting, revising, drafting, prewriting. Therefore, the tasks involved in the writing process should be viewed as able to be manipulated by a writer's particular vision and needs.

That brings me to you; what is your vision? What are your needs as a writer?

Since the process is often recursive, developing writers cannot follow a simple formula. They must identify how they write best, but beyond that, they must be able to assess a writing project to determine what step they should take next. Should they draft a few scenes to explore ideas? Or should they prewrite by brainstorming ideas or even journaling in a character's voice? Should they stop drafting to revise? Or if they do, will they end up stuck in revisions without ever finishing their project?

Writing a novel is a complex task that requires much dedication. However a writer can get from the starting point (blank page) to the ending point (polished novel) is a victory. The steps in the journey will not be the same for every writer or every project. That is why one of the most critical lessons a creative writer can learn is what kind of writing process works best for their individual writing styles.

That's where the concepts of pantser, plotter, or planter come in. Perhaps you haven't heard these terms before. Let me explain.

✓ Definitions

Pantser: a writer that does not plot prior to writing but instead prefers to "fly by the seat of their pants."

Plotter: a writer who plots every turning point and scene in their novel, sometimes to impressive detail.

Planter: a writer who embraces a bit of advance planning, but not to extensive detail and instead "pantses" their way through the rest.

A pantser approaches novel writing with little preparation. They may have an idea, and they sit down to a blank page and start writing. The act of writing is an exploration for them, and the story takes shape as they write. They don't know where it's going. They have an inner sense of the novel structure, how to build scenes, etc., and they do so naturally as they write. Of course, they also make a mess with a first draft as all writers do. The term pantser refers to these writers writing "by the seat of their pants."

With that context, then, you may be able to guess the kind of writer the term plotter refers to. Plotters like to prewrite to the extent that they know exactly where a story is going. They may have a detailed outline they follow. They may have a detailed beat sheet. No matter what they have, they will use that to guide them in the writing process. Some writers find that having a detailed structure

before they write diminishes the joy of exploration that is part of writing. Others argue that exploration already occurred during the prewriting process.

Writers tend to agree that plotters can draft more quickly because they have a clear guide while pantsers may find themselves “stuck” during the drafting process, not sure what to write next. That said, pantsers are able to jump into the writing without the days, weeks, or months spent plotting and planning. Like all things, there are potential benefits and drawbacks to both approaches.

Planters—a third approach—represent a combination of pantsers and plotters’ styles. Planters may have a few general ideas—they may know some of the turning points in the story and the ending—but they don’t iron out those details to an extreme. They have a strong sense of direction, and then they start writing.

I strongly encourage you to study yourself as you read this text, especially if you’d like to continue writing and publishing novels throughout your life. Work to understand and refine your writing process. Are you a pantser? A plotter? Or a planter?

As a developing writer, I had attempted to outline my books because I thought that was the way authors wrote. That did not work for me. But when I sat down to write “by the seat of my pants,” I struggled with a sense of direction. It took several years for me to work through these challenges, and through that process, I realized that I’m a planter.

It was the discovery of Blake Snyder’s *Save the Cat* that shaped my writing process the most. The beats of Snyder’s suggested structure offer me enough direction to write quickly, but they don’t require extensive plotting, which I found overly boring.

The beat sheet approach also suits my writing style. I like to “high point.” That means when I draft, I see the book globally, specifically the high points of the story. I write those scenes that speak to me the most, even drafting them out of chronological order at times. As a result, I write very quickly, but the result can sometimes become a jumbled mess I have no choice but to sort through in revision. Nevertheless, it is a system that works for me, and my challenge is to determine a system that works for you!

My process looks something like:

- Brainstorm *Save the Cat* beats to give myself a general idea of the high points in the story.
- Let my mind wander on those points.
- Write whichever scenes come to mind, leaving major holes between them in the document.
- Read through the document, adding bits and pieces to start connecting the scenes, still leaving some holes.
- Read through the document, adding character arcs to ensure the scenes connect in a logical way for the characters.
- Read through the document, smoothing over the scenes, so everything connects, and adding relevant emotions, settings, and other aspects, so there are no more holes.

So as you can see, I have a combination of prewriting (plotting my beat sheet) and then exploring through writing (pantsing). And there is significant revision to connect everything. It has taken me many years of writing and learning about writing to understand this part of my process. Learning that writers could be a mix of pantsers and plotters and discovering the concept of high pointing helped me to better understand myself.

And that’s why we read books about writing and books about craft! As we continue exploring concepts of novel writing such as premise, plot, character, etc. explore your own interests and process. The value of identifying the ways in which you write best cannot be overstated. Learn about yourself as a writer as much as you learn about the novel in this class.

✓ Exercises

1. Set a timer for five minutes, and write about prewriting strategies that you have found effective and also those that you have not found benefit in. Then, set the timer for another five minutes, and write about times you’ve written without prewriting. Which strategies have been the most effective for you? If you had to label yourself, which you don’t, would you identify your style as pantsers, plotters, or planters?
2. Think about a scene from a book or movie you love. How would you rewrite that scene? As you answer that question, are you: a) breaking down the scene, analyzing, and planning your rewrite, b) diving right into writing the scene without much planning, or c) planning some elements while rolling with the others, letting them come to the surface of your mind more organically? What does this exercise help you understand about your own inclinations in terms of identifying as a plotter, pantsers, or planters?

✓ Additional Resources

[Pantser, Plotter, and Plantser: The 3 Dominant Types of Writers](#)

[Plotter, Pantser, Plantser: What Are They, And How Do You Know What Type You Are?](#)

[Plotters vs. Pantsers: What Kind of Writer Are You?](#)

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3: The Power of Premise

As previously mentioned, the writing process is recursive and not the same for every writer. As a result choosing how to organize chapters in this text is a difficult, if not impossible, task. While one writer may begin with character, another may develop their plot first. That said, it seems relevant to me to consider premise first and foremost as it affects the development of both characters and plot.

Why is premise even more critical than character and plot? I intend to publish my novels. Of course, not all will be published or even finished, but since I want to see my books in the market, I have to consider the market. Starting a project by developing the premise of a work forces authors to consider the market early in the project, which I would argue is a time-saving, and in this industry, spirit-saving measure.

For instance, if I want to write a book about a sparkling vampire that falls in love with a human, it would be wise for me to study the market to determine: a) has this concept been “done” before, which of course it has, and b) is this a concept that audiences (i.e. agents, editors, and readers) are eager to consume. Had I not taken the time to study the market to determine that my sparkling vampire premise may not be the best option, then I may have spent a year or more writing a book that would struggle to find a place in the market based on premise alone.

Let me be clear that **time writing is not time wasted**. We grow as writers when we write, so **even if a book does not find its way to print, it has advanced us**, likely professionally and personally. That said, for those eager to see their books in print, an awareness of premise and its impact is critical.

As is the case with all aspects of writing, authors will value a study of the market to varying degrees.

A self-published author who writes quickly and publishes multiple books per year may look more closely at what is selling and write to those tropes. An author who publishes fewer books, perhaps one every few years, may consider some aspects of the market, but generally write what drives them as the market will continue changing as they develop their project. And then there are the other dominant authors whose writing helps shape the market.

The takeaway here is that **you, as an author, can choose how much you want to consider the market when you develop your premise**. However, if you intend to publish your work, especially traditionally (i.e. with a small press or large publisher), some consideration of what is hot and what is definitely not is helpful to you.

That is where premise comes in.

So what is a premise?

The premise is the basic concept of your story. Agents and editors will note they want to see “high concept” ideas. That means the premise can be explained in **a few, highly attractive words that will grab the attention of audiences**.

The premise is delivered in a brief statement, often referred to as a logline. The logline provides a kernel of information. It might be a sentence or two. It could be a phrase. Industry professionals often refer to it as the “hook” of a story in that it hooks the reader. The term “high concept” relies entirely on a novel’s premise. A premise should be unique and original, which is not easy to do. It’s often why the pitching strategy of x meets y works.

For instance, Gossip Girl has been done before, right? What about a book with the logline Gossip Girl meets The Hunger Games? Or what about The Golden Girls meets The Hunger Games?

See how meshing two well-known concepts can make something entirely new? If a reader loves The Hunger Games, they may wonder how that is going to be similar to The Golden Girls. Or Gossip Girl? What concepts will the author merge? What new concepts will be added?

This “high concept” of x meets y is a way to appeal to readers en mass, and that is really the goal of a high concept. There are other templates authors can use to develop a high concept premise as well.

✓ Premise Templates

Here I've included a few templates for writing a strong premise and examples.

1. The character and conflict template: In this template, you are sharing the main character and the conflict.
 1. Examples:

2. A brilliant hacker races to stop a digital apocalypse.
3. A teen witch battles dark forces to save her town.
2. The X Meets Y Pitch: In this template, a writer will include two “comp” or comparable titles that when merged suggest their own story.
 1. Examples:
 2. It’s Groundhog Day meets Pretty Woman.
 3. It’s Toy Story meets Transformers.
3. The X But Different Pitch: In this template, a writer will include one, or perhaps two comp titles but then note a key difference.
 1. Examples:
 2. It’s Castaway but in outer space.
 3. It’s Groundhog Day meets Pretty Woman but in a high fantasy world.
4. The Full Pitch: In this template, the author will include the character, obstacles, and stakes of the story in one sentence.
 1. Examples:
 1. A determined scientist braves a post-apocalyptic wasteland, facing mutant creatures and rival factions, to discover a cure for a deadly virus threatening the last remnants of humanity.
 2. A retired detective with dementia investigates his own unsolved case before his memory fades.

What did you think? Did any of these “hook” your attention? Did they make you wonder, “How is the author going to merge those two concepts? What would that look like?” Or, “How are the characters going to get out of that mess?” If the hooks got you thinking, if they piqued your interest, they served their purpose.

The benefit of developing a premise early in the process is that as you write, you can keep that focus in mind, and if that focus is already appealing to readers, you are a step ahead before you even begin. But how do you know what will appeal to readers? You ask.

Blake Snyder, who pioneered the “Save the Cat” concept we will discuss later in the course, suggested a very simple way to determine if your novel idea has a strong premise. He suggested you develop a one-line pitch and then just tell people - family, friends, random strangers in the store - what you’re writing. How do they react? Are they intrigued? Are they confused? Are they bored?

Trust the consensus of reactions - not one reaction. Also, share with people in your target audience, as that will carry the most value later. Finally, be sure to share with people who don’t already love and admire you. That is where you will find the most honest reactions to your premise.

Another way to know whether your idea has potential is to read - A LOT. Reading what is being published will help you see what has been overdone. Keep in mind as well that what is being published today was acquired in many cases by publishers at least 18-24 months ago, so it was being written at least two to three years ago. That makes it especially difficult to be current with your ideas and your writing if you’re looking at what’s published today.

Let’s step back, though, and reflect on your purpose. If you want to write a story that is near and dear to you and you have no care whether it is ever published, that’s fine. Write what you want! But if you have hopes of publishing your novel some day, then it’s imperative you think about concept. Agents tend to receive hundreds of queries each week! Most agents only sign a couple new authors each year. See how those numbers are not in a writer’s favor?

That’s why it’s crucial to have a premise that makes an agent or editor raise their eyebrows and read the next sentence of your query. All of the other aspects of a novel - structure, character, voice, point of view, tension, etc. we will discuss this semester matter, too. But it’s the premise that gets your metaphorical foot in the door.

✓ What are tropes?

As you consider premise, it is wise to have an understanding of tropes. A trope is a common character or plot element in a story. So for instance, we experienced a rise in the vampire tropes with the successes of True Blood, Twilight, and The Vampire Diaries. The Harry Potter books influenced an increase in “the chosen one” trope (i.e. a “chosen one” must save the world). There’s the zombie trope, the orphan trope, the witch trope - you get the idea. Each genre has its own tropes, for

instance in romance there are: enemies to lovers, slow burn romance, insta-love for those love at first sight stories, best friends to lovers, next-door neighbor to lovers, best friend's older brother romance, etc.

Some tropes are en vogue; others are overdone - at the moment. As the market changes, the interest in various tropes evolve as well. The key with tropes is to understand they exist and do some independent research regarding your story tropes. If you're writing science fiction, what are the tropes of science fiction to avoid? If you're writing romance, same question? What tropes are overdone in young adult novels? In mystery? In fantasy? In literary fiction? Use that knowledge as power to develop the story that you want to write while also considering the expectations of the current market accordingly.

✓ Exercises

1. Make a list of three of your favorite books or movies. Then, set out to the great internet to find the pitches for those works. They may be listed on the movie poster, on the back cover copy, or even on the front cover of the book. What are those loglines that the agents, editors, publishers, producers, and film companies released in the hopes of catching the attention of their audience? After you locate and consider them, write about what you learned through the process of studying the premises of the works you love.
2. Consider your novel premise. Write the premise in one sentences using the x meets y strategy. Then write the premise in another sentence using the template: When [character] wants [character's goal] but [obstacles], [character] has no choice but to [do what?] Or [what will happen - what are the stakes if the character fails]. Feel free to manipulate this template however you like; after all, not all writers think the same!
3. Consider your novel genre and age category. For instance, if you are writing YA fantasy, research the tropes for YA fantasy. Pay particular attention to dates of the resources you're studying. If they are recent, great. If they are not, then still read them, and then store that knowledge to get a sense of how the tropes have changed over time for your genre and age category. In studying the tropes, what have you learned that you may want to avoid? What tropes will you twist and turn to make something new and interesting?

✓ Additional Resources

[9 Common Character Tropes and Tips for Avoiding Them](#)

[10 Simple Plot Exercises you Need to do BEFORE You Write Your Novel!](#)

[How to Avoid Clichés in Writing](#)

[How to Ensure Your Story Has a Strong Premise](#)

[The Main Reason Your Story's Premise is Important](#)

[The Premise of Your Story](#)

[What is High Concept?](#)

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4: Plotting Your Novel

The challenge in writing - teaching it and learning it - is that it is so subjective. I studied plot structure in different ways before the Save the Cat approach clicked for me. I share the Save the Cat structure to help guide you because I think it is incredibly accessible. That said, there are other plot structure options for you to consider if you'd like to try another.

Blake Snyder was a screenwriter who broke down the "beats," or critical moments in effective scripts, in a way writers could adopt to strengthen their own writing. His strategies have been adopted for novel writing, too, most notably in Jessica Brody's *Save the Cat Writes a Novel* text, which I highly recommend. Essentially, the strategy breaks down the plot structure of stories into 15 beats.

As we enter the world of publishing, it's critical to keep in mind the value of intellectual property. The breakdown of beats for screenwriting and novel writing is not my intellectual property. For that reason, I am going to go guide you to Blake Snyder's intellectual property to continue exploring these ideas.

Here's what I'd like you to do. Visit www.savethecat.com. On the upper left, click on "Free Tools." You can review the "Get Started" link if you'd like. I have shared some introduction with you, but this also will introduce you to the concepts.

The bulk of the information can be found in the Beat Sheet Mapper. I'd like you to first read through the summaries of each beat. These summaries are very brief since I am sure their goal is for you to purchase the book (the book can likely be borrowed from a public library near you, and it is available in our college library collection). Nevertheless, the beats are explained in very basic terms in the Beat Sheet Mapper. I will also include a video of Jessica Brody explaining the beats more in the Additional Resources at the end of the chapter.

After you have read the summary for each of the fifteen beats, I want you to click on the Beat Sheets link under Free Tools and locate a beat sheet for a movie or book you know well. There are many options here. When you find a story you know well and read the beat sheet, you are likely to understand the beats much better, so that you can apply them to your own writing.

At the end of this chapter, I will also share an interactive spreadsheet an author has shared online that is a great tool. If you notice when you study the beats on Snyder's website, there are percentages attached to the beats. Screenwriting is very precise. The beats must appear at the perfect moment. While novel writing has some flexibility, authors must still keep the pacing of their stories in mind. If the stories are paced too slowly, reader will become bored and perhaps put down the book!

If the pacing is too quick, readers may not have time to process the information, and likewise, feel unengaged with the story. The spreadsheet I will share in the Additional Resources allows authors to input the word count or page numbers for their text (reference the word counts discussed for novels in the first chapter to plan accordingly) and then follow the pacing carefully.

So not only do the beats help you ensure your story includes relevant turning points and emotionally satisfying moments for readers, but they also keep authors on pace to deliver the best story they can to readers.

As you draft, keep in mind that the word counts will be approximate. You have to leave room for revision and polishing. But if your Set Up is meant to be 6,000 words according to the chart, and you've reached 15,000 words without getting to the catalyst, you are probably off the mark.

I also want to note that I have written nearly ten books with the beat sheet structure as a guide, and I still reference the definitions and text often. Reviewing this website, video, and or the text is not a "one and done" situation. You should review these materials often in developing your premise and plot, but also as you write and revise, too.

While the Save the Cat strategy works for me, I realize it may not work as well for you. Other options for studying plot structure include reviewing the Hero's Journey, which has been discussed heavily online in blog posts, websites, and then also in several craft texts. The Anatomy of Story by John Truby and Plot & Structure by James Scott Bell are other plot-teaching favorites if you're interested in exploring them.

✓ Plotting Craft Books

If the beats are not "clicking" for you, consider these other craft books that focus on plotting a novel. Check them out through your local public library at no cost!

- The Anatomy of Story, John Truby
- The Art of Dramatic Writing, Lajos Egri
- The Writer's Journey, Christopher Vogler

- Plot & Structure, James Scott Bell
- Story Genius, Lisa Cron
- Story Structure Architect, Veronica Lynn Schmidt

✓ Exercises

1. Scroll through the beat sheets collection on SavetheCat.com. Locate a beat sheet for a movie you love, but don't read the beat sheet. Once you know the beat sheet exists, you are good to move to the next step, without reading it. Watch the movie for the beat sheet. In a notebook while you watch, jot down the moments in the story that you feel qualify for each of the beats you've studied. Then, after you finish watching, access the beat sheet again on Snyder's website. How close is the beat sheet you created to the one posted? Did the exercise help you better understand the beats?
2. Start your own beat sheet. Using the resource from Jami Gold, input your expected word count based on the age category and genre of your novel. Then begin filling in your beats. Depending on whether you are a pantser, plotter, or plantser, this process may or may not be natural for you. Nevertheless, work to develop at least the major beats such as the Catalyst, Break Into 2, B Story, Midpoint, Dark Night of the Soul, and Finale. Remember, this is a starting point, and writing is revising. You can change any of this as you see fit, but progress can only be made by starting!
3. Do some plot research on your own. Search online for craft books about plot. Read samples of those books if you'd like through Amazon's Kindle sample feature. Borrow some from your library. Discover an explanation of plot that works for how you think about writing. Utilize the exercises available in those resources to further explore your plot ideas.

✓ Additional Resources

10 Tips for Plotting a Novel

How to Plot Your Way Through a Novel Series

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5: Creating Compelling Characters

While plot-driven novels are usually more commercial - thrillers, epic fantasies, etc, character-driven novels can be quieter and focus more on the internal growth and experiences of the character.

However, I argue that for a novel to truly impact a reader, it must balance character and plot. In the last chapter, we explored the contributions plot must make to a novel; let's move on now to the contributions characters make.

Your main character could be referred to as your protagonist, your MC, or your hero. Go with whatever works for you! Your character should be unique in some way. If you've read a story about a character like the one you have in mind before, then you want to change something about the character. Think of Enola Holmes. How many stories had we read or watched about her brother Sherlock? How exciting then to explore a story about her?

In *Gridiron Girl*, I write about a girl who wants to be the starting quarterback. There are certainly other books about girls playing football, but a story about a girl wanting to be quarterback differs from many of the stories we'd seen previously about girls playing the sport. And even more, a girl competing against her boyfriend for the position made Julia even more unique!

How can you rework your vision of your character to a place that's a little less expected? Creating a unique, unexpected character makes them interesting. Once you have an interesting character, the next step is taking them on an interesting journey, and that relies on their motivation. In other words, what does your character want?

Your character must want or yearn for something. This is part of how the MC drives the story. It's **IMPERATIVE** that you are able to answer the question: what does your MC want? Some people often referred to this want as the story goal.

In addition to the goal, you should understand your character's motivation, obstacles, and stakes.

✓ Goal, Motivation, Obstacles, Stakes

- Goal = what your character wants
- Motivation = why your character wants this
- Obstacles = what could prevent your character from achieving the goal
- Stakes = what will happen to your character if they fail

Knowing the goal, motivation, obstacles, and stakes is crucial to understanding your character and knowing how that intersection between character and plot occurs.

But we are also talking about character agency here. Readers want to read about a character who drives their own story. The action in the story should not be happening to the character; the character's decisions should drive the action. Often when characters are not showing agency, the writing feels contrived and convenient.

For instance, your protagonist must find something. It is critical to moving on in the story. What if the character finds it because someone delivers it to them? Problem solved!

No. This is too convenient, and the character has not shown agency. Create a situation in which the character must actively search for the item. Place obstacles in their way. Make them feel that they will never find this thing, and their life will change catastrophically as a result. Rely on their physical, emotional, or mental skills to find the item. That is how characters show agency.

✓ Wants vs. Needs

We've talked about what your character wants, but there is another level to that concept that helps complicate your character and your storytelling. Your character should want something **AND** need something. Some of the best stories create conflict when what the character wants is in direct conflict with what the character needs. For instance, in *Toy Story*, Woody wants to remain Andy's favorite toy, but what Woody needs is to find a way to accept Buzz. To develop strong characters, considering their wants and needs is important.

Let's also think about a character's arc. To be a truly satisfying story, the character must grow and change as a result of the plot. The character drives the plot, but the plot changes the character. The character cannot go through the moments of this story without being changed. That's what makes the story matter. That's what makes the reader satisfied.

A story that comes to mind is the classic film, *Pretty Woman*. In this film, Julia Roberts plays the role of a prostitute named Vivian that encounters a very wealthy businessman named Edward. She accompanies him on his week-long trip, so that he doesn't have to pay any attention to romantic matters, and instead, he can focus on business alone. Of course, he falls in love with her.

At the beginning of the story, Vivian is on a dark trajectory in life. We see her before world in the setup, and it is grim. In her line of work, she has a rule not to kiss a man on the mouth because it is too personal. This is something important to her as a character. So her character arc is fairly hopeless at the beginning of the story. However, as she spends time with Edward, we see her potential, and she grows. Suddenly, her life doesn't appear as grim, although that reality is hovering.

In the plot, there is a moment when Edwards tries to kiss Vivian, but she resists. Later in the story, though, she kisses him on the mouth. We see that this moment is critical because she has abandoned her personal rule. She has changed as a character. This is a moment in the story when character and plot collide. Edward knows the significance of this moment, too. They both know it. Something has changed.

After Vivian has changed from her time with Edward, she cannot go back to her "before" world. Her character arc has altered its trajectory.

Think about stories you know well. What are those critical moments that a character trait collides with a plot point, and we know the trajectory of the character's arc has changed? Watch for these moments in movies and books you consume.

Notice how we didn't talk about a character check sheet or physical attributes of the character. Developing character is so much more than a basic worksheet about the superficial attributes of the character. Some writers develop a Pinterest board with images of their characters, so they have that in mind. In my sports series, I have rosters for the teams that list the height, weight, and positions of the characters. I also have the rotation for the volleyball team, so I know who is in which position as I develop the game time situations. There are absolutely those logistical details that are important for you as you develop your character, but I want to encourage you to look at your characters more deeply than those attributes, especially early on!

✓ The List of 20

Sometimes it can be difficult to develop unique ideas for your character's traits, goals, motivation, obstacles, and stakes. To solve this problem, a good romance author friend, Susan Meier suggests a list of 20. That means she asks herself a question: What could my love interest's occupation be in the story? And she answers that with a list of 20 ideas. She said the first four or five tend to be the expected, overdone options. Then she gets a few viable ideas around 8-12. She finds that the option she ultimately selects tends to be near 15, and the last few are often quirky options to round out the list rather than viable candidates.

You might want to adopt the list of 20 for your own books. Or you might not. The idea here is to move beyond the expected. If you've seen it done before, you probably don't want to do it again. If you expect that a main character in a mystery should be a police detective, then are you missing an opportunity to write a unique main character? If you think a murderer should be malicious and terrifying, are you missing the opportunity to write the story of the murderous nun or grandmother?

Finally, if you're having a difficult time with your list of 20, consider trying your hand at artificial intelligence. Ask an AI program to answer the question, and see what ideas you can mine from the responses.

✓ Exercises

1. Brainstorm a list of five different "wants" a character might have. Once you have your five goals, then brainstorm a corresponding "need" for each. How can you make those needs contradict the wants? How will that add conflict and further layers to your story?
2. Explore an artificial intelligence resources such as ChatGPT by entering a question into the search for a List of 20. For instance: Give me a list of 20 character traits an overworked mom might demonstrate every day. Or, can you make a list of 20 ways to show a person loves the outdoors? How is your experience with AI? Is it something you might use in the future or avoid as you continue working on your novels?
3. Create a vision board for your characters. Use a program such as Pinterest - you can keep the board private if you'd like - and collect photos of what your main character might look like, outfits they would wear, their closest friends, where they live, places important to them. This will help you visualize and build relevant details in to your story.

✓ Additional Resources

[Character Development](#)

[Giving your Characters Agency](#)

[Your Ultimate Guide to Character Development](#)

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6: Building a World Beyond Time and Place

World building, as a term, is more often used when discussing the fantasy or science fiction genres. However, I like to use the term for all fiction.

If you think back to elementary or even high school, what is the definition of setting? I'm guessing you have the words "time and place" memorized. The issue, though, is setting is so much more than time and place. It's the entire world you build around your character. I want you all to think about setting as such - world building - so that you push yourselves to develop worlds that are rich beyond simply time and place.

For instance, my debut novel series, which I've mentioned a few times in this book already, was set at a fictional high school called Iron Valley. Although the protagonists are not the same for each of the four books, the main characters know each other. When I wrote their stories, I had to build a world around them. The world included the places the characters spent their time, the traditions they had for sporting events, their team colors and rivals, etc. Some of the stories are set at a summer camp, so I had to build the camp map and the schedule of events.

The setting in these books isn't even that prominent in the story, but I still had to build a world for my readers.

In my second series, the setting is a mardi-gras-like carnival for teens. The teens wear masquerade masks, dress up, and do fun things like ropes courses, mazes, and glow-in-the-dark bumper cars. The setting in these books is like a character itself. My first readers had lots of questions: why do they do this? Who pays for it? What is the point? I had to take all of those comments into consideration and build the answers into the story, so the world was realistic.

These books are contemporary stories. They are not fantasy or sci-fi, but world-building was still necessary.

✓ A World Bible

A word bible for a novel is meticulously crafted to capture the essence of the fictional universe for your story. You can include intricate details about the world's geography, history, cultures, societies, languages, technology, magic systems, and unique aspects of daily life. As a writer builds their series, the bible becomes a comprehensive guide that ensures consistency and continuity! It is also an author's saving grace, especially if they are like me and tend to forget and overlook details!

What world building is necessary in your book? Where does the character live and work? Who are they around? What colors do they love to wear? What does their home look like? What does their town look like? Are they in a city or a small town? Do they have lots of friends around them all the time or just a few close friends? How do they spend their weekends? Their mornings? What do they like to drink and eat? Some of this may seem like character traits, and you'd be right, but these traits are built into the world around them.

Nevertheless, the point is that details make a story. They make a world. They make a showing moment. They make a character. Yes, plots tend to be recycled, but the details in the stories change, and that's where stories are made new. Think about that as you build your world and as you show instead of tell (more on that, soon!).

As you develop your worlds, keep these tips in mind:

- **Maintain consistency:** The world must follow its own rules, whether those rules are magical, technological, or contemporary societal norms. You must understand the rules of your world, so that you can ensure consistency. It takes some critical thinking to assess your story from all angles to ensure there are not violations of the world in what you develop.
- **Include rich details:** Our lives are rich with history, major events, wars, geography, culture, climate, economics, class systems, and political hierarchies. You do not have to develop all of these for your world, but you should develop several that are impactful to your character or plot.
- **Incorporate conflict:** Just as character development and plotting create opportunities for conflict, so does the world building for your story. Develop political structures, alliances, and power struggles that impact the dynamics of your characters, and therefore, the conflict in your story.
- **Show perceptions:** How do your characters view their world? Are they sarcastic about the politics? Do they honor the religious and society systems without question? How do the world's elements affect your characters' beliefs, values, and daily lives?
- **Avoid dumping:** Introduce your world to readers gradually. Avoid overwhelming readers with information dumps - large chunks of information all at once. Show the world through the character's actions, experiences, and dialogue rather than exposition.

✓ Exercises

1. Look around you right now. Find three things in the room that say something about you. I have a laundry basket in my room filled with clean laundry. The fact it's sitting there might show someone I don't love doing housework, and that would be correct. But also, as I'm writing this in 2022, my daughter just had surgery, so my house is messier than usual. I'm working to get by. If you show a character that keeps a near perfect house suddenly have a mess around them, that SHOWS the reader something. Something is off in that character's world.
2. Create a map of your fictional world. Use a fun software program if you'd like, but the key is to include all of the landmarks relevant to your story. Consider how the geography of your place influences the culture, story, and interactions between characters? Where do they spend their time? As a result, what does that say about how they spend their time? How can your world become an impactful aspect of the story, both in terms of your characters and your plot?
3. Write a list of the daily life and traditions in your world. What are the common rituals, ceremonies, festivals, and traditions? Why are these impactful to your character's community? How are the social norms, gender roles, and traditions relevant to your characters and your plot?

✓ Additional Resources

[3 Best Worldbuilding Apps for RPG Gamers and Fantasy Writers](#)

[Nanowrimo Worldbuilding Resources](#)

[Worldbuilding Resources: The Ultimate List](#)

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7: Scenes as Building Blocks

Scenes are the building blocks of novels. A scene is a unit of a story that progresses the narrative in a meaningful way. A key piece of information must be revealed. For example, we might see a new character with hints of how this character will be impactful in the future. The scene may offer some emotional depth that we didn't understand previously, or it might plant foreshadowing for a key moment to come in the story.

Something **must** happen in the scene for it to be meaningful, and therefore included in the book.

If a scene does not achieve this, it may need to be cut from the story - what writers have often referred to as "killing your darlings." But we are getting ahead of ourselves. If you can make a scene work hard for your story, it can stay. That's a better choice than cutting a scene you love!

✓ Tasks of a Scene

For a scene to be impactful, and therefore included in a novel, it should achieve two goals:

1. The scene must propel the story forward in some way. The movement forward could feature any combination of action, character development, dialogue, world building, etc. The key is that the characters are closer to the resolution of the story than they were in the previous scene.
2. The scene must cause a change. The characters must not leave a scene exactly how they entered it. The "movement," as mentioned above, causes a change that the characters cannot ignore.

Some writers advocate for an action-reaction-process-decision model when developing scenes for their stories. Essentially that means an action occurs in a story. As a result of that action, the characters react. After everything settles from the reaction, the character mentally processes what has occurred and makes a decision about how to act from there. Then, the next action occurs, there is a reaction, processing, and a new decision.

As characters work through this sequence, they change. They are moving forward in their story goal. It is this kind of movement forward and changing for the characters that drives scenes and therefore stories.

Additionally, scenes escalate a story. As your plot builds, the stakes for the characters should be raised. With each scene, the situation becomes more dire for the characters. Escalating the story through scenes that are building more and more tension increases the stakes. Yet, the process of escalating tension scene after scene is not an easy task.

✓ Common Scene Problems

Now that you have some basic knowledge about scenes, let's discuss some common issues new writers face while writing them:

1. Showing every moment: While we live chronologically, not skipping over chunks of time, that is actually rather boring in a novel. Readers only need to see what is relevant to the story goal. As a result, it is not necessary to show a character waking up, brushing their teeth, eating breakfast, etc. unless those moments are absolutely critical to the story goal - such as the character is working to wake up every day rather than sleep through the day and only be awake at night. Readers expect that time is passing and they are not seeing every moment of it.
2. Including details that don't belong: Readers expect that when a writer shares something, they do so because that detail is relevant to the story goal. For instance, in a mystery, all details matter. They are either clues or red herrings. If writers share details that do not matter, readers that pride themselves on solving the mysteries may become exceedingly frustrated and find the experience of reading your novel unsatisfying. If you include a scene, it must matter.
3. Scene length negatively affects pacing: As a writer, you must develop an eye for what matters in a scene and what can be cut. If you include too much description or unnecessary dialogue, you may drag down the pace of a scene. On the contrary, if you don't give enough details, then the reader may feel they are not rooted in the time or place of the scene. Some banter is good in the dialogue, but too much is problematic. The best way to gain a sense of the best scene length is to read - a lot.

It's important to also note that scenes are not necessarily chapters. Writers use chapter breaks to create cliffhangers for readers, so they will want to read the next chapter, which ends with another cliffhanger to compel them to read further, and so on. That said, all three of those hypothetical chapters may have featured the same scene.

Or perhaps an author writes longer chapters, so there are two scenes within the same chapter. What you might notice in novels you're reading are scene breaks. These occur within chapters and might look something like:

Publishers I've worked with have differing styles for how to signify scene breaks. Sometimes, they even get cute with some sort of symbol or emoji-styled break. In any case, the takeaway is that scenes and chapters are not necessarily the same units within a novel.

While this book is meant to offer you an introduction to novel writing, the reality is you will learn so much from reading many novels and from writing your own! As you write your own scenes, work to achieve the points discussed in this chapter. Keep this one last tip in mind: understand the purpose of each scene you write.

Avoid writing scenes because you are not sure what direction your character should take. Write scenes with purpose. Understand the goal of the scene, whether that be to reveal character, advance the plot, create tension, or provide other necessary information - and here's a hint: each good scene should achieve a combination of those tasks, rather than simply one per scene!

✓ Exercises

1. Choose two of the tasks scenes should achieve: reveal character, advance the plot, create tension, or provide other necessary information. Observe people around you, either in your home or in a public venue. Write a fictional scene inspired by what you observe that achieves two of the tasks. If you are feeling brave, add a third task to the scene. If you're really up for a challenge, can you incorporate all four tasks in your scene? Remember pacing as well! Keep the scene brief and on task.
2. Tension and conflict are at the heart of a good story, so let's practice writing them! Create a scene where two characters with conflicting goals or beliefs are forced to work together. Explore the tension, dialogue, and actions arising from their clash of interests.
3. Practice building suspense and escalating tension by writing a suspenseful scene where a character is in imminent danger. Focus on building tension through pacing, sensory details, and character reactions. Experiment with cliffhangers and unexpected twists. Have fun!

✓ Additional Resources

[8 Steps to Writing a Perfect Scene - Every Time](#)

[10 Tips for Writing Better Scenes](#)

[Manage Your Novel Scenes with Checklists](#)

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8: Developing Your Voice

Aah, voice. One of the most elusive aspects of creative writing. Have you ever picked up a novel and immediately loved the sound of the words on the page? Did you hear a voice in your head that was incredibly appealing? Or on the contrary, did you find that the voice was unappealing, and you couldn't imagine spending two or three hundred pages with that voice?

That is the power of voice.

Agents and editors want to also feel compelled to listen to the voice of a story for hundreds of pages, but they find it difficult to explain what it is about voices that appeal to them and voices that do not. That leaves us as authors to work on developing the voice that appeals to us and hope that audiences agree!

So how do you develop a voice that works for your story?

People think in different ways, and your characters should, too! You may have heard before that each character should have their own distinct voice. Early in my writing career, I recall thinking about this differently than I do now. For instance, I would have each character use a different turn of phrase or word choice. That helped, but it was not enough.

Point-of-view characters, or those that are the voices of our stories, choose their words because of their thoughts, and their thoughts are influenced based on what is important to them as people.

Let me use some of my current manuscripts as examples here. In the first book, *Gridiron Girl*, the protagonist, Julia, compares many things in life to football. She uses sports analogies and football metaphors because she lives and breathes football, and has her whole life with three older brothers that all played the position of quarterback. That's how she thinks. That is her voice.

In book 2, *Disorder on the Court*, the protagonist, Melanie, plays volleyball. Her best friend is a science genius who conducts scientific experiments in his backyard. Melanie tends to think in volleyball analogies and scientific terminology. That's who *she* is.

What your character loves influences them. I'm a mother of four children and a writer/teacher of writing. In my everyday life, I reference parenting stories and moments and writerly advice. I connect with people and with life through the lens that I use to see the world.

As characters do.

Earlier in the chapter on character, you gave some thought to what makes your characters unique. You made some choices about how they connect with the world. When you develop their voice, you want to be sure you are choosing metaphors, analogies, advice, and everyday dialogue based on how that particular character sees the world.

Voice is so important yet also enigmatic. I strongly encourage you to review the additional resources at the end of the chapter but more than that to set out on a journey to study voice, not just now in your writerly journey but at every step in the journey.

More than once - honestly, more than twenty times - I have heard agents and editors say that the first thing that grabs them about a piece of writing is the voice.

Voice, voice, voice!

Some authors have a natural voice that readers cannot get enough of. Other authors do not. Of course, all authors can work on developing their style and therefore their voice.

Let me also note that there is a difference between the narrative voice of a story and an author's voice. Yet there are also similarities, too. I know - why is everything associated with writing so contradictory?!

An author has a specific writing style. It could be more literary with descriptions and metaphors throughout the pages. Or it could be more snarky and telling - or any number of alternatives.

All of that said, although an author has a voice and a style, they will make decisions to vary that voice with each novel they write. Take for instance the points I made earlier in this chapter about how my characters see the world. My authorial voice may be similar in terms of the style of the writing for every book in the series, but the narrative voice will differ.

I fear this chapter has raised more questions than answers with a rather nebulous discussion of voice. That said, explore the exercises and additional resources at the end of the chapter, and continue critically analyzing your own authorial voice and the narrative voice of your character. The more that you read and write, the stronger your voice will become.

✓ Exercises

1. Read the first paragraph of ten different books in less than ten minutes. How do the voices for each novel differ? Are any of the voices more appealing than others? If so, what kinds of voice appeals to you, and what voices do not? How does this knowledge influence your own narrative voice?
2. Choose a passage from a favorite author and rewrite it in your own words, incorporating your style, tone, and perspective. Experiment with different genres and writing styles. Write a scene in the style of a mystery novel; then try it as a romantic comedy. How does this help you better understand your voice?
3. Write a letter from one of your characters to another. Incorporate that character's voice in the details. Then, write another letter as a reply. The reply should be written in a different voice, one that reflects that character. What does this exercise teach you about both of these characters?

✓ Additional Resources

[5 Ways to Develop Your Writer's Voice](#)

[How to Find Your Writer's Voice](#)

[Voice: An Agent's Perspective](#)

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9: The Rules and Strategies of Dialogue

Dialogue is critical to strong storytelling. It's difficult to master, but when an author writes dialogue well, a novel really shines.

So what does it mean to write dialogue well?

As you may have picked up by now, experts rarely agree 100% on concepts in their fields. The same is true about writing dialogue. However, there are some theoretical concepts about dialogue that tend to be generally accepted.

For instance, dialogue is meant to enhance a story. Long passages of narrative or description without dialogue can be difficult to engage. Blending narrative, description, and dialogue demonstrates the skill of the author.

✓ Brain Break

Grab a novel near you - as a writer, you likely will not have to go far! Flip through the pages. Are there any pages with large paragraphs and no dialogue? Those kinds of pages tend to slow down the pace of a novel. On the contrary, are there any pages with dialogue? Great. Study the length of the dialogue. In most cases, the dialogue will be delivered in short bursts that include some description and narrative mixed throughout. It is that kind of blending that creates a rich complexity to a story on the page.

The dialogue should be natural to the characters. It shouldn't be stilted or gratuitous. Let me explain with an example.

Lucy closed the fridge and set the milk on the table. "You don't like milk, I know."

"No. I don't. I have that allergy to it."

"I can get you some water instead."

Okay, this is purposely bad writing. What you see here is that the writer uses dialogue to tell the reader something, but it's awkward because if both Lucy and the other character know about the milk allergy, why would they talk about it? Why wouldn't she just get water for her friend? Dialogue should be used to deliver *relevant* information to the reader.

Interestingly, what is *not said* in dialogue matters, too. What is left unsaid, often referred to as subtext, creates tension between the characters.

To deliver on this concept, I want you to think of an important conversation you've had with a loved one. In that conversation you wanted them desperately to say something in particular - to apologize, to declare their love, to come clean on a secret - but they didn't. What is left unsaid, then creates a tension between you and that loved one. You can similarly build tension in your story with what you leave unsaid in the dialogue.

The common advice for learning to write dialogue used to be to listen to people talk - to go to a public space and eavesdrop. Movies, television shows, and books are also great examples of dialogue, though, so look to those for guidance.

Above, we discussed the need to blend dialogue, description, and narrative on your pages. You may be wondering exactly how to do that. Let's get into the practical conventions of dialogue to demonstrate that blending process!

There are some general rules about dialogue you should keep in mind as you write your novels. Examples help to show these points, so I'm pulling a passage from my young adult novel *Gridiron Girl* to share.

✓ Example

"My sister's looking smug, so can I assume you girls won?" Owen said.

I kissed his cheek. "We did indeed."

"Nice job."

"I don't want to brag," Ally said in a voice that declared she was totally bragging, "but no team in the conference will be able to touch us this year."

"The season hasn't even started yet," Owen countered. "You don't want to be too confident. You never know what'll happen."

The characters in this scene are Julia, Ally, and Owen. Ally and Owen are twins. Julia and Owen are dating.

First, notice that each time a new person speaks, there is a paragraph break. This signals to the reader a new person is speaking. You don't want to place dialogue from more than one person in the same paragraph as that can get confusing for the reader. Every time a new person speaks, break the paragraph.

Also, notice the speech tags. Usually, it's best to use "said" as a tag. Said is viewed as an invisible word. It cues the reader that someone is speaking, but they don't really register the word itself. It doesn't break up the flow of the writing. Notice also that I broke that rule myself when "Owen countered" with a different opinion. It's okay to break the rules, but do so sparingly and only when you can use a strong verb to do so. And avoid speech tags with melodramatic verbs such as "he snarled," "she sobbed," "they groaned."

✓ Punctuation by Culture

In the United States, the publishing community uses double quotations for dialogue, but other countries, don't necessarily follow that structure. In the United Kingdom, for instance, publishers use single quotes. Follow the expectations of the country where you intend to publish.

There are two ways to denote who is speaking in a line of dialogue. One is a speech tag such as "Owen said." The other is called a beat. In a beat, you give a sentence of action prior to the dialogue. The character performing the action is the character that then speaks. In other words, if you provide an action for a specific character and follow that action with a line of dialogue, you are telling the reader that the character who you named as performing the action is also the character speaking.

You can see this here in the second line. Julia is the point-of-view character, so when the text reads, "I kissed his cheek" and is then followed by a line of dialogue, we know Julia is the one speaking in that dialogue.

✓ Who is speaking?

So to reiterate, the reader knows who is speaking by:

1. Paragraph breaks to signify a new speaker.
2. Speech tags, preferably "said."
3. A beat of action that is in the same paragraph as the dialogue being spoken.

Also notice there is not a beat or speech tag on every line of dialogue. It can get distracting to have a speech tag on every line, especially if there are only two characters speaking in the scene. You want to offer beats and speech tags often enough for the reader to follow who is speaking, but not so often that it becomes distracting from the content of the conversation. This is a delicate balance.

The best way to learn it is to read. Look at some of your favorite stories, and study these elements of dialogue in the text.

When it comes to conventions of dialogue, the goal is to use a variety of strategies that are also natural. Notice that Owen's first line of dialogue is followed by a speech tag; his second line of dialogue has no tag, and his last line has a tag that breaks the dialogue in the middle. Notice Julia's line includes a beat before it, and Ally's dialogue includes a speech tag with a beat-like description in the middle of her dialogue. That demonstrates variety.

So mix up your use of beats and speech tags. Place them in a natural location. For instance, if a character is taking a bite of food as the beat, should they take the bite before or after the dialogue? If it's before, it says something about their manners, talking with their mouth full. If you don't want to convey that kind of message, it makes more sense for the beat to follow the line of dialogue.

✓ Exercises

1. Visit a public place and eavesdrop on conversations. Take notes on how people speak, their choice of words, tone, and expressions. Use these observations to create authentic dialogue for your characters. What are some of the things you hear that your characters would also say? What would your characters be offended if someone had said to them?
2. Write a dialogue scene where characters are discussing a sensitive topic without directly mentioning it. Explore how they use subtext, gestures, or pauses to convey their underlying emotions and intentions through relevant beats with the dialogue.

3. Choose two characters with distinct personalities, and write a conversation between them, ensuring their speech patterns, vocabulary, and sentence structures reflect their backgrounds and ages. Then, flip the script. Reverse the roles of the characters in some way. Reassign the power from one character to another. Analyze how their dialogue changes based on their new positions, personalities, and objectives.

✓ Additional Resources

[How to Harness the Power of Subtext](#)

[How to Write Dialogue: Formatting, Examples, & Tips](#)

[How to Write Great Dialogue](#)

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10: Conclusion

We've reached the end of our journey into the art of novel writing. I hope you have found the exploration beneficial.

My goals have been to teach you a bit about novel writing and to give you the tools and know how to continue learning and exploring on your own.

Learning how to learn about writing and the publishing industry and filling your toolbox are the best things you can take away from this book. I couldn't possibly include every piece of knowledge about novel-writing on these pages. The book is intended as an *introduction* to novel writing. I am blessed to have many friends who are novelists, and even those who have been writing for decades admit they are still learning their craft.

The learning process never ends.

With that in mind, I want to share a list of craft books. Each semester that I teach novel writing, I offer this list to students, so that they may make a selection from it to read for their craft book project. Essentially, that project requires them to read a book about craft and then to develop a project to share the book's key takeaways for their classmates.

While I admit that there are many other books that could be included on the list, it offers solid suggestions. I want to challenge you to follow this text with another book on craft - this time of your choice.

When you finish that book, choose another from the list.

And so on.

Continue learning about writing. Continue reading books in your genre and age category but in others as well.

And, of course, continue writing.

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✓ Books on the Writing Craft

The Anatomy of Story, by John Truby

The Art of Fiction, by John Gardner

Becoming a Writer, by Dorothea Brande

Bird by Bird, by Anne Lamott

The Elements of Style, by Strunk & White

The Emotional Craft of Fiction, by Donald Maass

The First Five Pages, by Noah Lukeman

Getting into Character, by Brandilyn Collins

Hooked, by Les Edgerton

How to Write a Damn Good Novel, by James N. Frey

How to Write Bestselling Fiction, by Dean Koontz

On Becoming a Novelist, by John Gardner

On Writing, by Stephen King

On Writing Well, by William Zinsser

Plot & Structure, by James Scott Bell

Reading Like a Writer, by Francine Prose

Romancing the Beat, by Gwen Hayes

Save the Cat Writes a Novel, by Jessica Brody

Steering the Craft, by Ursula LeGuin

Story, by Robert McKee

Story Genius, by Lisa Cron

Wired for Story, by Lisa Cron

Wonderbook, by Jeff VanderMeer

The Writer's Journey, by Christopher Vogler

Writing Down the Bones, by Natalie Goldberg

The Writing Life, by Annie Dillard

The Writing Life: Writers on How they Think and Work, by Maria Arana

Writing the Breakout Novel, by Donald Maass

Zen in the Art of Writing, by Ray Bradbury

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